

A second argument can be presented via an example.

The drowning child

You are walking to class past St. Joseph Lake, and see a child drowning in the lake. If you don't go in to help the child, the child will die. If you do go in, your clothes will get wet. (You really don't like having wet clothes.) What should you do?

To most people, the answer here seems pretty obvious: you should go in and help the child. But why?

Obvious answer: the situation in which the child lives and you have wet clothes is better than the one in which the child dies and you stay dry. But that assumes that consequentialism is true.

Consequentialism

An action is right if, of all available options, it would lead to the best outcome, and wrong otherwise.



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